

Game Over It: Design System

Tokens and reusable components for the student game backlog tracker. Every value on this sheet is a token; components reference tokens, never raw values.

STEP A: STYLING APPROACH

Plain CSS with `:root` custom properties, plus CSS Modules per component.

DECISION	DETAIL
Tokens live in	one <code>:root</code> block in <code>client/src/styles/tokens.css</code>
Component styles live in	a <code>*.module.css</code> file beside each component
Why this one	No build plugin and no library to learn; it matches the plain CSS the course already covers, and it keeps every value in one readable block. A component refers to <code>var(--color-primary)</code> , never to <code>#8B7BFF</code> .
What that buys	the whole app can be re-themed from one file.

STEP B: COLOUR TOKENS

FIVE INTERFACE COLOURS

<code>--color-bg</code> page background text on it: 15.84 : 1 #12101A	<code>--color-surface</code> cards, panels, inputs text on it: 14.11 : 1 #1E1B2E	<code>--color-text</code> body text on bg: 15.84 : 1 #ECEAF5	<code>--color-primary</code> buttons, links, active states on bg: 5.72 : 1 on surface: 5.09 : 1 #8B7BFF	<code>--color-accent</code> the one call to action on bg: 10.30 : 1 #FFB020
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STATUS COLOURS: THE ONE DOCUMENTED EXCEPTION

The app's defining idea is a four-state status, and colour is how a list of 200 rows stays scannable at a glance. Rather than inventing four new hues, **one reuses a core token**: `--color-playing` is `--color-primary`.

<code>--color-muted</code> want to play on surface: 7.06 : 1 #A9A5C0	<code>--color-playing</code> playing = primary on surface: 5.09 : 1 #8B7BFF	<code>--color-success</code> completed on surface: 9.63 : 1 #4ADE80	<code>--color-danger</code> abandoned, also the destructive Button on surface: 6.05 : 1 #FF6B6B
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Nine colour tokens, eight distinct values: five for the interface and four for the statuses, one of which (`--color-playing`) reuses `--color-primary`. The four statuses are one semantic layer, and **colour is never the only signal**: `StatusBadge` always prints the status word, so all four states stay readable without seeing colour at all.

Contrast note: the ratios above are WCAG 2.1 relative-luminance contrast, computed for each pair (not estimated). All **16** text-on-background pairs used by the app reach at least 4.5 : 1; the lowest is **5.09 : 1** (`--color-primary` on `--color-surface`), the worst case in the whole app and still passing. The focus ring (`--color-primary` on `--color-bg`) is **5.72 : 1**, above the 3 : 1 that UI components need. Re-running the check gives the same digits.

Why the palette is dark. The subject is games and a backlog is a long list of cover art. A dark surface keeps cover images from fighting a white page and matches where the user already is. This was decided **once, in the token definitions**, not per screen. *Also, I prefer dark aesthetics.*

STEP C: TYPE SCALE

Three sizes. That is all this project needs. Set below at their real sizes.

Backlog

Heading · 26 px · 700 bold · --font-heading · screen and section titles ("Backlog", "Add a game")

A backlog is a long list of cover art, and this is the size it is read at.

Body · 15 px · 400 regular · --font-body · paragraphs, list text, form text

12 games · 3 playing · last synced 2 days ago

Small · 12.5 px · 400 regular · --font-small · captions, field labels, counts, the footer

Font: the system stack ("Segoe UI", Arial, sans-serif), no webfont to download, nothing to go wrong offline.

STEP D: SPACING RULE

One base unit: 8 px. Every padding, gap and margin in the app is a multiple of it.

- tight: label to its input, badge to title 8 px --space-1
- standard: inside a card, field to field 16 px --space-2
- between sections on a screen 24 px --space-3
- between major screen regions 32 px --space-4
- screen edge padding: phone / desktop 16 px --edge-phone · 24 px --edge-desk

Bars are drawn to scale against this rule. This single rule is what makes the UI feel designed rather than ad hoc; it is worth more than picking exact pixel values, and it is the reason GameCard looks identical on every screen.

RENDERED LIVE FROM THE TOKENS

BUTTON: 4 VARIANTS

Save gameConnect SteamCancelDelete

STATUSBADGE: 4 STATUSES

Want to playPlayingCompletedAbandoned

RATINGSTARS

★★★★☆
8/10 · read-only is onChange={null}

★★★★★
10/10

FORMFIELD: VALID & ERROR

Title
Hollow Knight

Hours played
-3
Hours cannot be negative.

GAMECARD COMPOSES SEVERAL

cover art
Hollow Knight
PC · Switch
Playing★★★★☆

STEP E: REUSABLE COMPONENTS

Pulled straight from the component tree in Doc 2, Step C. Each is built once and rendered wherever it appears.

COMPONENT	LEVEL	APPEARS ON	PROPS IT TAKES
Button	atom	everywhere	variant (primary · secondary · cta · danger), onClick, disabled, children
StatusBadge	atom	Backlog, Game detail, Steam import summary	status (want_to_play · playing · completed · abandoned)
RatingStars	atom	Backlog, Game detail	rating (1–10 or null), onChange (null = read-only)
Label	atom	Add game, Game detail, Steam connect	htmlFor, children
Spinner	atom	every screen that fetches	label (optional)
BackLink	atom	Add game, Game detail	to, children
Input / Select / Textarea	atom	Add game, Game detail, Steam connect	value, onChange, id, invalid, placeholder
FormField	molecule	Add game, Game detail, Steam connect	label, htmlFor, error, children (one control)
SearchBar	molecule	Backlog	value, onChange, placeholder
FilterChips	molecule	Backlog	active, onChange, counts
SortSelect	molecule	Backlog	value, onChange
GameCard	molecule	Backlog (in the grid)	game (the whole row), onClick
EmptyState	molecule	Backlog (two variants), Steam	title, body, action (optional)
ErrorMessage	molecule	every screen that fetches	message, onRetry (optional)
ConfirmDialog	molecule	Game detail (delete)	open, title, body, onConfirm, onCancel
SteamProfileCard	molecule	Steam	profile (steamid64, personaName, avatarUrl, profileUrl, lastSyncedAt)
Header / Footer	organism	all four routes (shared layout)	none (Header reads the nav config)
GameForm	organism	Add game and Game detail (edit)	initialValues, onSubmit, onCancel, submitting, errors
GameList	organism	Backlog	games, loading, onSelect
GameDetails	organism	Game detail (read view)	game, onEdit, onChangeStatus
SteamConnectPanel	organism	Steam	onConnected, connected
SteamImportSummary	organism	Steam	imported, updated, skipped, lastSyncedAt

STEP F: RESPONSIVE PLAN

Below 640 px: phone - Game grid 3 columns → 1 stack, the main media query. - Filter chips scroll horizontally in one row rather than stacking, so they never push the list below the fold. - Add game: optional fields collapse behind a toggle, so title and status need no scrolling. - Game detail: cover stacks above the title; the two-up rows stack to one column. - Steam: connect and sync panels stack in the order the user performs them.	640–1024 px: tablet - Grid stays at 2 columns. - Forms stay single column. - Screen edge padding stays at 16 px.	1024 px and up: desktop - Grid becomes 2–3 columns using Grid. - The Add form splits into two columns. - Game detail splits cover beside the title. - Screen edge padding goes 16 px → 24 px.
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These become min-width media queries in the module CSS. **Hard requirement: no horizontal scrolling at 375 px wide.**

ACCESSIBILITY CHECKLIST: WORKED THROUGH BEFORE BUILDING

- Every text-on-background pair reaches at least 4.5 : 1; all **16** pairs computed; the lowest is **5.09 : 1** (--color-primary on --color-surface).
- Real semantic elements: <header>, <nav>, <main>, <footer>, <button>, <form>, <label>, never a <div onClick> for everything. GameCard is a link, not a clickable box.
- Every meaningful image has alt text: cover art gets the game title as its alt; purely decorative art uses alt="".
- Every form input has a matching <label> via htmlFor + id; this is what FormField exists to guarantee in one place.
- Every link and button is reachable by Tab with a visible focus ring (--color-primary, **5.72 : 1** against the page, above the 3 : 1 UI-component minimum).
- Errors are announced in text, not by colour alone: StatusBadge always carries the status word, so the four states are readable without seeing the colour.
- ConfirmDialog traps focus and returns it to the Delete button on close, so a destructive action is never triggered by muscle memory.